

Chapter 56-1: 笔友 (Pen Pal)

Ning Fuyi went down to the first floor and cast aside the distracting thoughts in her mind. Just as she was about to walk into the night, she suddenly heard faint sounds coming from a distant room. She stopped abruptly and turned to look, seeing a dim light appearing in the window.

That room seemed to be where Qiu Yi stayed. Ning Fuyi sensed something was wrong and closed her eyes to extend her divine consciousness.

The aura emanating from the room was not pure. Besides Qiu Yi, there seemed to be another extremely weak presence—one that Ning Fuyi felt she had encountered somewhere before.

Ning Fuyi didn't intend to pry into others' privacy, but that aura was really similar to demonic energy, so she had to investigate.

She lowered her phoenix eyes slightly, held her breath, and walked silently to the door.

It was indeed Qiu Yi in the room. She seemed still immersed in sadness, unaware of anyone's presence at the door. She was biting her lip tightly, sitting at the table with her back to Ning Fuyi, writing furiously on something glowing.

That familiar aura was emanating from the object in her hand. Ning Fuyi shifted slightly to the side and from a clever angle saw what Qiu Yi was holding.

It was a huge feather, large enough to span two adult palms, emitting a faint white glow. Qiu Yi held a brush and wrote. After finishing a sentence, those characters magically disappeared.

After a while, a new line of text appeared. This handwriting was much more beautiful than Qiu Yi's—written in clerical script¹, every stroke elegant and graceful.

Ning Fuyi's gaze darkened. She tapped on the door frame with her finger. Hearing the sound, Qiu Yi startled, and the brush in her hand fell to the ground with fright, ink splattering everywhere.

She leaped up, instinctively hiding the feather behind her back.

"You!" Qiu Yi wanted to scold her for peeping, but afraid that Chu Qingqiu might hear, her voice urgently became smaller: "What are you sneaking around and peeping at?"

Perhaps due to guilt, her eyes were somewhat evasive.

"You didn't close the door," Ning Fuyi said innocently. "So I can't be considered peeping."

"I know, I know. Won't you leave now?" Qiu Yi urged.

However, since Ning Fuyi had already detected demonic energy, how could she leave so easily? She glanced nonchalantly behind Qiu Yi: "What were you writing?"

"None of your business!"

Though she said this, her body remained tense, clearly showing guilt.

Ning Fuyi didn't want to continue this standoff. She turned: "The Divine Venerable should still be awake. Since you won't tell me, I'll go ask her."

Tattling was always an effective trick. Before Ning Fuyi's skirt had fully turned, she heard Qiu Yi urgently calling: "Wait!"

Ning Fuyi looked back at her and raised her chin toward the thing behind her.

Qiu Yi looked angry but dared not speak. She glared at Ning Fuyi resentfully and slowly pulled out the object from behind her.

It was indeed a feather, with feathers so green they seemed to glow, eye-catching like a green gemstone. The ink marks on it had already faded, looking completely clean.

"See? It's just a feather. What's all the fuss about?" Qiu Yi muttered quietly, but her hand gripped the feather tightly.

Ning Fuyi didn't listen to her words. Her gaze fell on the feather—the demonic energy was indeed emanating from it. But it was extremely weak; if she hadn't been a demon for a hundred years, she would definitely have difficulty detecting it.

"What did you write on it?" Ning Fuyi asked again.

She had now removed the smile from her eyes, her gaze stern. Her dark phoenix eyes were like an abyss, causing panic to surge in Qiu Yi's heart when she looked at her.

"I didn't write anything..." Qiu Yi still wanted to argue, but facing Ning Fuyi's gaze, the words were swallowed back.

"Where did you get this thing?"

"I picked it up."

"Hasn't your master warned you not to carelessly collect things of unknown origin?" Ning Fuyi frowned. "And writing on it—do you know that if your mind gets bewitched, your master would be the first to die?"

"I wouldn't..." Qiu Yi instinctively said, but was interrupted by Ning Fuyi.

"This thing has demonic energy on it. If nothing unexpected, it belongs to the demon race." Ning Fuyi said coldly.

Qiu Yi was immediately shocked, her mouth agape and forgotten to close, quite bewildered and at a loss. She looked down at the feather in her hand, her fingertips gripping it until they turned white.

"Give it here." Ning Fuyi extended her hand.

Qiu Yi was somewhat reluctant, but hearing that this thing was a demonic object, she was both angry and afraid. In the end, she could only listen to Ning Fuyi and hand over the feather.

Ning Fuyi pinched the feather with two fingertips, turning it over and examining it. The down on it was delicate and soft—it should have fallen from some demonic beast.

She muttered something in a low voice, and flames began to burn from her fingertips. The feather was destroyed from the center. As the flames grew stronger, faint black smoke rose and dispersed in the air.

Now Qiu Yi also detected the demonic energy. She felt a chill of fear, clenched her teeth tightly, and hatred welled up in her eyes.

She hated the demon race the most, yet she had talked with a demonic object for so long.

After hearing Chu Qingqiu's words earlier, Ning Fuyi could roughly guess her state of mind. So she pinched her fingertips to extinguish the fire. The firelight reflected in Qiu Yi's eyes, then gradually disappeared.

"When did you pick up this thing?" Ning Fuyi asked.

Qiu Yi looked down at the ashes on the ground and didn't speak for a long time before opening her mouth: "When I went to Tongchuan."

It had actually been several months ago. Ning Fuyi was speechless for a moment. She turned the burned feather remains in her hand: "So what did you say to this thing?"

"It didn't bewitch me." Qiu Yi looked up, her voice somewhat urgent. "Everything we said was ordinary conversation. I occasionally complained to it, and it spoke gently and reasonably, like an older sister. That's why, that's why I never thought it was a demon."

"Can you tell what this demon's identity was?" Ning Fuyi asked again. Hearing that the thing hadn't harbored malicious intentions, her expression also softened somewhat.

Knowing she had caused trouble, Qiu Yi could only answer whatever Ning Fuyi asked. She shook her head: "No, it never told me much."

Ning Fuyi nodded and turned to leave, but was blocked by Qiu Yi stepping in front of her.

"What, you want to silence me now?" Ning Fuyi raised an eyebrow.

"Who wants to silence you!" Qiu Yi said irritably. Her eyes uncomfortably glanced toward Chu Qingqiu's direction, her voice as low as a mosquito's hum: "Can you not tell my master?"

"I don't want her to be disappointed."

The expression on Qiu Yi's face changed like clouds and wind. She didn't want to submit to Ning Fuyi, but helplessly was caught in a compromising position by her. She could only force herself to lower her head, her palms almost bleeding from clenching.

"Indeed, if Chu Qingqiu knew she had taught such a foolish disciple, who knows what she would think." Ning Fuyi smiled, still wanting to provoke her a bit more.

"Ning Fuyi, you!"

Seeing the person about to be made to cry by her, Ning Fuyi was finally satisfied and withdrew her hand, throwing the destroyed feather into her Thought Pearl: "Alright, I don't have a hobby of tattling to elders."

With that, she didn't linger any longer. Waving her hand, she left bathed in the evening breeze, her figure quickly disappearing among the flower shadows.

Only then did Qiu Yi feel relieved. She stepped back and sat down, hugging her knees and picking up the brush still wet with ink from the ground. After staring at it for a long time, she raised the back of her hand and secretly wiped away the tears from the corner of her eyes.

Footnotes:

1. **隶书 (Clerical Script)** - A style of Chinese calligraphy that evolved from seal script during the Qin and Han dynasties, characterized by its wide, flat strokes and elegant appearance.